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Sam Altman, OpenAI will reportedly back a startup that takes on Musk's Neuralink

Sam Altman is in the process of co-founding a new brain-to-computer interface startup called Merge Labs and raising funds for it with the capital possibly coming largely from OpenAI's ventures team, unnamed sources [told the Financial Times](#).

The startup is expected to be valued at \$850 million. A source familiar with the startup said the deal could change the landscape of AI and OpenAI's future.

Merge Labs runs Tools for humanity, scanning digital data for signs of humaneness.

Merge Labs is developing a brain-to-computer interface.

implanted in the brain, although its company has not yet been approved by the FDA.

Neuralink is a company that aims to help people with severe paralysis by connecting their thoughts to a computer. Its valuation is currently \$1.5 billion.

Neuralink (a subsidiary of OpenAI) aims to help humans interface with computers. The company says its tech could take the world by storm.

Long before Silicon Valley became obsessed with the concept of artificial general intelligence (AGI), it was enamored with “the singularity.” Musk has used [the term](#) to describe a time when AI surpasses human intelligence. The more classic definition (after a 1960’s novella of the same name by Dino Buzzati) means the merging of tech with humans.

Altman [blogged](#) about “The Merge” in 2017. “Although the merge has already begun, it’s going to get a lot weirder. We will be the first species ever to design our own descendants,” he

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postulated at the time, citing research work he saw at OpenAI, where Musk was still a co-founder.

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Julie Bort is the Startups/Venture Desk editor for TechCrunch.

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Anna Monaco
term "AI agent"
chatbots, she
made sense

"I had this personal pattern, and I noticed that a lot of other people had this pattern, of putting very important CRM data in spreadsheets just because it was the most flexible thing," Monaco told TechCrunch. "But it was actually a pain to maintain. There's so much manual work involved. So [I] just went down this rabbit hole of building a product for myself and wanted to reimagine what a spreadsheet could look like with the full power of LLMs."

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“The interesting thing that happened when we fundraised is some people we pitched just kept on using and paying for the product,” Monaco said. “I think that was a cool part of it. We found a lot of value from it internally and our investors, not even just our investors — other investors that we talked to — are still using

Paradigm isn't just an AI upgrade, it's a million in value goal. Legacy adding AI to

Monaco said because Paradigm's spreadsheet workflow that spreadsheets



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“What I’m seeing is a fine balance of how do you build

lot of value now but also sets you up really well for the future? That’s the question that I asked myself a year ago when I was starting the company.”

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Senior

Becca is a senior editor covering startup trends and stories.

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sleep tech

Kate Park — 3:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

Roughly one in three adults in the U.S. regularly gets insufficient sleep, driving demand for tools that can monitor, analyze, and enhance rest. [Eight Sleep](#), founded in 2014, offers AI-powered sleep tech products that promise to transform your bed into a preventive health device.

The New York-based startup announced Tuesday that it raised a fresh \$100 million round from investors such as HSG, Valor Equity Partners, Founders Fund, Y Combinator and athletes including Ferrari F1 driver Charles Leclerc, and Zak Brown, who is the CEO of McLaren F1.

With this round, Eight Sleep has raised a total of \$260 million.

total, Pitchbook says. The startup's Series C in 2021 was a post-money round that doubled since

“If we succeed, we’ll be an international company achieving unicorn status,” said Zatarain, co-founder of TechCrunch.

Eight offers sleep tracking and enhanced sleep offers featuring a breathing pad that automatically adjusts temperature. It can also detect snoring and respond, according to the company.

The company has seen strong sales, expanding its product line in 2023. After 100 hours of recorded sleep data, it says.

Eight, which employs just over 100 full-time staff, is now expanding beyond the Pod with its Sleep Agent, an AI-driven system that leverages large language models to create thousands of digital twins for each user and predict outcomes, with the goal of optimizing nightly recovery. This approach shifts sleep technology from reactive tracking to proactive, personalized intervention, said Zatarain.

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Eight Sleep raises \$100M to expand its AI-powered sleep tech

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Eight Sleep currently ships to over 30 countries—including Canada, the UK and EU nations, Australia, Mexico, and the UAE—and is now planning to expand into China. The CMO told TechCrunch that China, as one of the world's largest consumer markets, is seeing a rise in a health-conscious middle class that prioritizes sleep and overall wellness.

Regarding sensitive health data, Zatarain said the company complies with each locale's regulations, including for data storage.

"Privacy is foundational. All data is encrypted, never sold, and fully private. We comply with GDPR and CCPA, and on all our devices, we've embedded in our products a focus on privacy and the invasiveness of data," Zatarain said.

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